

Eyelid Swelling

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Reviewed/Revised Oct 2025

A person may experience swelling in one or both eyelids. Swelling may be painless or accompanied by itching or pain. Eyelid swelling is distinct from [bulging eyes](#), although a few disorders can cause both.

Causes of Eyelid Swelling

Eyelid swelling has many causes (see table

[Some Causes and Features of Eyelid Swelling](#)). It usually results from an eyelid disorder but may result from disorders in and around the eye socket (orbit) or from disorders elsewhere in the body that cause widespread swelling.

Common causes

The most common causes of eyelid swelling are allergic, including:

- [Local allergy](#) (contact sensitivity)
- More widespread allergic reaction (for example, [angioedema](#) or [allergic rhinitis](#))

Swelling of one place in one eyelid is common and is most often caused by a blocked oil gland ([chalazion](#)) or a bacterial infection of a hair follicle ([stye](#) or [hordeolum](#)).

Less common causes

Less common causes of eyelid swelling include:

- Disorders that cause generalized body swelling, particularly a type of kidney disease called [nephrotic syndrome](#)
- Bacterial infection of the skin of the eyelids and around the eyes ([preseptal cellulitis](#) or [periorbital cellulitis](#))

- Chronic inflammation of the eyelid margins ([blepharitis](#))
- Underactive thyroid gland ([hypothyroidism](#))
- Overactive thyroid ([hyperthyroidism](#))

Rare but dangerous causes of eyelid swelling are infection within the orbit and around and behind the eye ([orbital cellulitis](#)) and blockage of a vein at the base of the brain by an infected blood clot ([cavernous sinus thrombosis](#)).



Some Causes and Features of Eyelid Swelling

Cause	Common Features*	Diagnostic Approach
Eyelid disorders		
Allergic reaction affecting only the eyes	Itching but no pain	A doctor's examination
	Pale, puffy eyelid or eyelids and sometimes pale, puffy conjunctiva (the membrane that lines the eyelids and covers the front of the eye)	
	Sometimes in people who have had a previous episode, been exposed to an allergen, or both	
	Affecting one or both eyelids	
<u>Blepharitis</u> (inflammation of the edges of the eyelids)	Yellow crusts on lashes	A doctor's examination
	Eye itching, burning, redness, sores, or a combination	
	Sometimes accompanied by seborrheic dermatitis (inflammation of the skin characterized by greasy scales on the scalp and face)	
	Usually affecting both eyelids	
	Clusters of fluid-filled blisters on reddened	



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